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WRITING SAMPLE | TECHNICAL EDITING

MAKING A TECHNICAL STANDARD LEGIBLE

Before-and-after edit of the NIST AI Risk Management Framework 1.0 (NIST AI 100-1, January 2023, p. 1)

A before-and-after edit of the NIST AI Risk Management Framework, showing the diagnosis, the structural rewrite and selected line-level decisions, with the source's hedges kept intact. Independent editing sample by Megi Zimmermann; this version revised October 2026. The original passage is quoted verbatim from NIST AI 100-1; the diagnosis, rewrite and notes are mine. Not commissioned, reviewed or endorsed by NIST.

Editorial brief

Audience: an intelligent general reader who needs to understand why AI risk differs from ordinary software risk. Constraint: preserve NIST's careful claims and hedged stance; do not import a stronger argument than the source supports.

Original passage

> While there are myriad standards and best practices to help organizations mitigate the risks of traditional software or information-based systems, the risks posed by AI systems are in many ways unique (See Appendix B). AI systems, for example, may be trained on data that can change over time, sometimes significantly and unexpectedly, affecting system functionality and trustworthiness in ways that are hard to understand. AI systems and the contexts in which they are deployed are frequently complex, making it difficult to detect and respond to failures when they occur. AI systems are inherently socio-technical in nature, meaning they are influenced by societal dynamics and human behavior. AI risks – and benefits – can emerge from the interplay of technical aspects combined with societal factors related to how a system is used, its interactions with other AI systems, who operates it, and the social context in which it is deployed.
>
> These risks make AI a uniquely challenging technology to deploy and utilize both for organizations and within society. Without proper controls, AI systems can amplify, perpetuate, or exacerbate inequitable or undesirable outcomes for individuals and communities. With proper controls, AI systems can mitigate and manage inequitable outcomes.
>
> AI risk management is a key component of responsible development and use of AI systems. Responsible AI practices can help align the decisions about AI system design, development, and uses with intended aim and values. Core concepts in responsible AI emphasize human centricity, social responsibility, and sustainability. AI risk management can drive responsible uses and practices by prompting organizations and their internal teams who design, develop, and deploy AI to think more critically about context and potential or unexpected negative and positive impacts. Understanding and managing the risks of AI systems will help to enhance trustworthiness, and in turn, cultivate public trust.

Editorial diagnosis

- Lead with the actual stakes. The source opens with a comparison to conventional software and reaches the distinctive AI problem only after a long opening clause.
- Translate terms of art without deleting them. "Socio-technical" should remain available, but the reader needs to see that it means outcomes depend on code, data, people, institutions, and context together.
- Replace nominalizations with action and verbs. Repetition of "AI systems" and phrases such as "Understanding and managing the risks" obscure who must do what.
- Preserve the source's restraint. NIST says managing AI risks will help enhance trustworthiness; it does not guarantee safety, fairness, or public trust.

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WRITING SAMPLE, CONTINUED | EDITED VERSION

Edited version

AI systems pose risks that are in many ways unique, even though there are many standards and best practices for mitigating the risks of traditional software. An AI system may be trained on data that changes over time, sometimes significantly and unexpectedly. Those changes can affect how the system functions and how trustworthy it is, in ways that are hard to understand. Both the system and the setting around it are often complex, so failures can be hard to detect and hard to respond to when they occur. AI is also socio-technical: outcomes can depend not only on code and data, but on who operates the system, how people use it, what other AI systems it interacts with, and the social conditions in which it is deployed.

That combination can create both harm and opportunity. Without appropriate controls, AI can amplify inequitable or otherwise undesirable outcomes. With appropriate controls, it can mitigate and manage inequitable outcomes.

Risk management is a key part of responsible AI. It can prompt the people who design, develop, and deploy a system to think more critically about its context, intended aims, and possible positive and negative effects, including the unexpected ones. Responsible practices can help keep human needs, social responsibility, and sustainability in view throughout those decisions.

Organizations that understand and manage these risks help make their AI systems more trustworthy, and that, in turn, helps cultivate public trust.

Editorial note

The main barrier was not technical difficulty but buried hierarchy: the passage had the right claims, but the reader had to work too hard to discover which one governed the rest. I moved the distinctive risk first, then translated "socio-technical" through concrete actors and conditions. I kept the term because it is useful; I removed the surrounding abstraction that made it inert. I also kept the strength of NIST's verbs: with proper controls, AI "can" mitigate inequitable outcomes, and risk management "will help" trustworthiness, so the edit promises nothing the source does not. The edit should make the expert easier to understand, not more certain than the expert intended to be.

Selected line-level decisions

Original	Edited	Editorial reason
While there are myriad standards and best practices...	AI systems pose risks that are in many ways unique, even though there are many standards and best practices for mitigating the risks of traditional software.	Lead with the governing claim; keep NIST's "in many ways" and its concession, and claim nothing about what existing standards cover.
AI systems are inherently socio-technical in nature...	AI is also socio-technical: outcomes can depend not only on code and data, but on who operates the system, how people use it...	Retain the useful term; define it through actors and conditions.
Understanding and managing the risks of AI systems will help to enhance trustworthiness...	Organizations that understand and manage these risks help make their AI systems more trustworthy...	Name who acts instead of a nominalization, and keep the source's "help."
...cultivate public trust.	...and that, in turn, helps cultivate public trust.	Keep the source's causal chain without promising that trust will follow.